

Wild Garlic Information Pack

Introduction

Wild Garlic is a native, perennial plant in the same family as leeks and onions. As early as March in the UK, thick, green carpets of wild garlic leaf transform the woodland floor, providing a vital early spring food source for wild fauna whilst permeating the countryside with a sweet, garlicky aroma.

Farm Information

We forage Wild Garlic ourselves on the Highden Estate in the South Downs National Park, West Sussex. Our patch is a steep, north-facing bank of ancient woodland that we share with a roaming herd of Fallow deer that we manage as part of our woodland regeneration project. For this reason, our foragers are careful just to take a handful of leaves from each plant, ensuring the new shoots and flowering head remain intact to allow the plant to survive and reproduce. This careful foraging method is vital so not to disturb the delicate ecosystem of the ancient woodland and encapsulates the regenerative mindset that guides our decision making at Chef's Farms.

More

Wild garlic is one of the spring ephemerals, alongside snowdrops and bluebells, that mark the turning of the seasons. Their life cycle depends on growing, maturing and flowering in the brief window of late winter/early spring when soil moisture is high and the days are getting longer but, crucially, the deciduous trees in their native forests have not yet regained their leaves, shrouding the forest floor in gloom.

Being packed with flavour, easy to identify and abundant, Wild Garlic is a favourite of foragers and chefs. The young leaves can be used as a flavourful alternative to spinach, as well as in pesto's and oils. The white flowers begin to open in mid-April and make a bright garnish or addition to salads. Moving into May, the flowers turn into juicy, round seed pods that can be pickled into Wild Garlic capers which pop with the texture of caviar, finishing the cycle of this is incredibly versatile plant.

Media

Photos and videos on the shared album, more available upon request! See our recent Instagram reel on Wild Garlic for more info.